

Low Tide

We come when the tide goes out,
baring its sharp rocks, the bouquets
of mauve and mint-green anemones
waving like rows of children's hands.

I walk by limbs of giant kelp piled up
on the shore like sleeping bodies,
the rivulets like veins spreading out
from pebbles lodged in the sand,
anatomies waiting to be washed away.

And there, seagulls are playing in the water,
white wings and white foam gnashing
at the shore where two little girls
are scuttling over the rocks
in pink-shelled jackets, hunting
to fill their pockets with broken glass.

I remind myself that when you died, you did not
become a weed or a pebble or a bird,
a drowned plant or a pattern in the sand or a seagull
with wings beating frantically inside its chest,
or another of these sand-castle similes.

I could tell you how anemones use venom
to paralyze small crabs and eat them.
I could observe that when the tide comes in,
it's easy to forget the ebb and flow of tragedy,
to linger on mussel shells that gleam like
Grecian masks in the setting sun.

And I know your answer would not be heard
beneath the roaring water, the grains of memory
dragged against an unforgiving shore.

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In my alleyway,
the smear of feathers that was once
a bird
sings me to sleep.

I am walking to your apartment, unwinding
a thread of dental floss—my mother's good, worsted yarn,
the color of ripe berries, would be wasted in piss-stained streets.
Even in a dream, one must be practical.

The alleyways become rivers and the rivers
become veins and I walk the path of your body,
its familiar bones a maze where the city and the girl
you left echo themselves, one inside the other.

A pigeon fish pecks at the floss. Windows lick their lips.
Dumpsters release bubbles like clams. The coffee shop
we went to on Tuesday mornings is full of children
who stare at me behind piles of star-stuffed scones.

I meet strangers with your face. Cashiers with the dignity
of 17th century portraits, crevices of their skin gleaming
with white paint: their eyes, your eyes. Without you,
the city is impressionist—the harder I look, the less it makes sense.

When a bird has no body, it sings of dark laurels,
rotting seeds and broken nests,
twigs scattered on the ground like music notes,
an unraveling melody.

I am walking to our apartment that only exists in a dream.
There, I will find the sound of your laughter,
the unmaking of your bed, the couch, the cutlery, the curated lamps,
and flying in the rafters, a memory of your body,
the dissonant chord I forget upon waking.